

“Spontaneous Resistance and Sector-Based Strategic Battle during the Liberation War of Bangladesh (1971)”

Introduction

The Liberation War of Bangladesh in 1971 evolved through two complementary phases:

1. **Spontaneous popular resistance** immediately after the Pakistan Army launched Operation Searchlight on 25 March; and
2. **Planned, sector-based strategic warfare** under the organized command of the Mukti Bahini.

Together, these dimensions shaped the military, political, and psychological foundation of Bangladesh’s independence.

1. Spontaneous Resistance (March–June 1971)

a. Reaction to Operation Searchlight

The brutal attack on civilians, intellectuals, and political activists on 25 March created a wave of decentralized and emotionally charged resistance. Ordinary villagers, students, labourers, and local politicians spontaneously took up arms in defense of their communities. This phase was not centrally commanded but was driven by patriotic outrage.

b. Role of Police, EPR, and Students

Members of the **East Pakistan Rifles (EPR)** and the **police** defied Pakistani orders and joined the uprising. Students of Dhaka University, Chittagong University, and various colleges formed early guerrilla squads, sabotaging military convoys, destroying bridges, and collecting abandoned weapons.

c. Local Liberation of Areas

In many districts—such as Kushtia, Brahmanbaria, Satkhira, Rangamati, and parts of Sylhet—Pakistan's army was temporarily pushed out. These early victories proved that the Bengali population was capable of armed resistance, significantly boosting morale.

d. Impact of the Early Resistance

1. Prevented Pakistan Army from swiftly establishing total control.
2. Bought time for political leaders to form the **Mujibnagar Government** and reorganize the freedom fighters.
3. Created momentum that later transitioned into an organized military structure.

2. Transition to Organized Warfare

By late April and May 1971, it became clear that spontaneous resistance needed coordination. The Provisional Government appointed:

- **Col. M.A.G. Osmani** → Commander-in-Chief of the Bangladesh Forces
- A structured command system dividing Bangladesh into **11 sectors**

Thus, the war evolved from scattered resistance to organized and technically planned operations.

3. Sector-Based Strategic Battle (June–December 1971)

1. The Sector Command System

Bangladesh was divided into **11 sectors** for operational efficiency. Each sector had:

- A **Sector Commander** (usually a Major or Lt. Colonel)
- A **Headquarters across the border in India**
- **Sub-sectors** for operational flexibility
- Training camps for new recruits
- Dedicated guerrilla forces and regular forces (Mukhti Fauj)

Below is a concise overview:

Sector	Commander(s)	Main Operational Area
1	Major Ziaur Rahman	Chattogram, Cox's Bazar
2	Major Khaled Mosharraf	Dhaka region
3	Major K. M. Shafiullah	Sylhet
4	Major C. R. Dutta	Tripura–Comilla belt
5	Major Mir Shawkat Ali	Rajshahi–Rangpur
6	Major Nazmul Huq → Lt. Col. Salahuddin	Bogura–Dinajpur
7	Major Quazi Nuruzzaman	Mymensingh
8	Major Abu Osman Chowdhury	Kushtia–Khulna
9	Major M. A. Jalil	Jhalokathi–Barisal
10	(Naval Command)	Coastal and riverine warfare
11	Major Abu Taher	Hill Tracts and special operations

2. Strategic Objectives of Sector Commands

- **Coordinate guerilla and conventional operations**
- **Conduct cross-border raids**
- **Train and equip fighters**
- **Disrupt the mobility and supplies** of the Pakistan Army
- **Create liberated zones** (muktanchal)
- Prepare for eventual **joint operations** with the Indian military

4. Nature of Sector-Based Warfare

1. Guerrilla Warfare

Sector forces commonly used:

- Hit-and-run attacks
- Demolition of railway lines
- Ambushing military convoys
- Sabotaging fuel depots
- Destroying bridges, ferries, and power stations
- Killing collaborators and intelligence operatives

2. Strategic Battles and Key Operations

a. Battle of Belonia (Sector 2)

Massive fight against Pakistani troops, weakening their grip on Feni–Noakhali.

b. Battle of Kamalpur (Sector 11)

One of the fiercest engagements; Pakistani fortifications were heavily challenged.

c. Battle of Chattogram Hill Tracts (Sector 1 & 11)

Vital for controlling the southeastern corridor.

d. Operation Jackpot (Sector 10)

A famous naval commando operation in August 1971, destroying ships and ports in:

- Chattogram
- Mongla
- Chandpur
- Narayanganj

It crippled Pakistani supply lines.

3. Training and External Support

Indian support played a major role:

- Specialized guerrilla training
- Artillery and communication support
- Safe zones for refugees and freedom fighters
- Later, direct military involvement (December 1971)

5. The Combined Final Offensive (December 1971)

By November–December:

- Mukti Bahini controlled vast rural areas
- Pakistan Army was weakened by constant guerrilla pressure
- India formally entered the war on 3 December

The joint **Mukti Bahini–Indian** operations rapidly encircled major cities.

Dhaka fell on **16 December 1971**, marking Bangladesh's victory.

Conclusion

The victory of 1971 resulted from the **synergy between spontaneous resistance and organized military strategy**.

- The **spontaneous uprising** demonstrated national unity and delayed Pakistani consolidation.
- The **sector-based system** transformed a popular revolt into a scientifically managed liberation campaign.

Together, they ensured Bangladesh's emergence as an independent nation.